Leading With Curiosity In An AI-Enabled World

Hunter McMahon Forbes Councils Member
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Hunter McMahon, COO, iDiscovery Solutions, Inc.



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Enabled by artificial intelligence, the average user can search for and retrieve information more easily than ever. Likewise, leaders across all industries are inundated with dashboards, metrics and real-time analytics that promise instantaneous answers to complex questions.

We can pull reports in seconds, track real-time data points, and see predictive analytics with a few clicks. This accessibility is undoubtedly powerful, but it can also be deceptively assuring because information alone lacks something crucial—perspective.

Without experience and curiosity, which can transform that information into knowledge and wisdom, leaders risk making shallow decisions that overlook deeper insights.

The DIKW Model

At its core, the well-established DIKW model (Data, Information, Knowledge, Wisdom) is still a valuable framework to help us understand how data or information alone does not yield actionable insights. Let's use brewing coffee as an example.

Data

Data is a collection of raw or unorganized facts.

1 cup, 20 ounces, 1 minute, 5 minutes

Information

Information is data that has been organized and prepared for analysis or understanding.

1 cup of coarsely ground coffee, 20 ounces of boiling water, steep for 1 minute, steep for 5 minutes

Knowledge

Knowledge is an understanding of what the data means and why it matters.

To make the best cup of coffee, pour 20 ounces of boiling water over 1 cup of coarsely ground coffee, wait 1 minute, then break the crust, stir, and let steep for 5 more minutes.

Wisdom

Wisdom is the ability to turn knowledge into action.

Based on my schedule and knowledge of how to make the best cup of coffee, I need three pounds of coffee per month to ensure I don't run out, which is for the greater good.

As AI advances, a curiosity-centric approach to information is essential for transforming data into knowledge and, ultimately, wisdom.

Transforming Information Into Wisdom

Leading is not about perfection but rather intention. To unlock true potential, leaders must intentionally foster an environment where curiosity thrives. Using techniques like asking "*Why,"* giving space by *Pausing*, and replying with "*Yes, and"* encourages deeper solution-oriented thinking. These approaches encourage teams to look beyond the surface of information and challenge initial assumptions.

The Power Of Asking "Why"

A simple yet powerful tool in all leaders' arsenals is the question, "Why?" The concept of "Five Whys" was initially popularized by Sakichi Toyoda, a founder of Toyota. There is no magic to the number five—it is about the intentional process of asking the question until you get to the actual root cause (aka understanding).

For instance, a team at a professional services company wants to reduce the time needed to prepare new engagement documents. The initial ask was to improve integration between two systems. Through asking "Why," it turns out data validation (the input) was the most time-consuming part, being done numerous times for what would become obsolete information. Repeatedly asking "Why" allowed the team to redesign the workflow to validate data later in the process, saving substantial time without more technology.

In the world of instantaneous answers, the first answer may be incomplete and/or incorrect. Asking "Why" helps leaders and teams understand the cause rather than just seeing the result. Understanding the cause allows for more strategic thinking and better solutions.

Pausing To Give Space

Not all team members thrive in a rapid-response-style environment. Pausing is not about slowing down productivity, but rather creating space for deeper reflection. When leaders pause before reacting to data, they give their teams room to think critically and analyze thoughtfully.

Following the previous example, the team that devised the solution did not start with that change in mind. Several pauses happened, allowing space to think, give feedback and ask different questions. It was in that space that the new ideas came out.

Instead of jumping straight to solutions when a problem arises, leaders can ask “Why” and refrain from offering their thoughts until others have offered their own. Pausing allows teams to discuss, explore alternative views and even uncover issues that might have otherwise gone unnoticed. By creating this space, leaders foster a culture of curiosity where quick answers give way to thoughtful consideration.

Encouraging “Yes, and…”

When teams present insights or suggestions based on data, the instinct is often to critique or question validity (“But, have you considered…” “But that won’t work when…”). The “Yes, and” approach encourages building on ideas rather than breaking them down (“Yes, and if we want it to work here, we would need to…”). It allows teams to further develop initial ideas, cultivating an open, collaborative environment.

Thinking back to the example, the initial ideas proffered were not viable by themselves. Rather than focusing on the why not, the team focused on how it could work. That’s when the ideas kept building and eventually led to the real solution.

This technique can be particularly useful when brainstorming what to do with the knowledge you have developed from asking ”Why” and pausing. It signals to teams that their input is valued, fostering an environment where curiosity and creative problem-solving can flourish.

Curiosity In The Billable Hour World

In a world where every minute counts, taking what may feel like the long way around can seem illogical. It makes leveraging AI for quick and easy answers very tempting. So, how do you reconcile the pressures for efficiency and fast answers with the need for strategic solutions based on wisdom?

Focus on the value you give clients, not the amount of time spent. Build teams willing to question, explore and engage deeply with information to uncover insights that cannot be seen on the surface. By fostering a culture of curiosity, leaders enhance their decision-making and empower their teams to achieve extraordinary results. Transform information into wisdom and strategy into action.